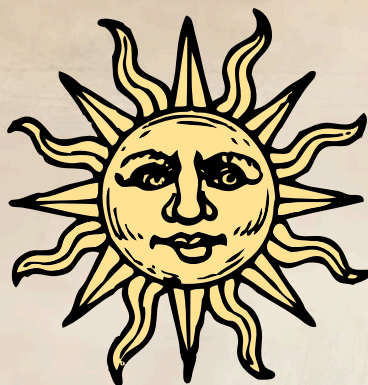




FACTIONS & RUMORS

A GM-TOOLKIT FOR DRAGONBANE ADVENTURES

Work in Progress v0.2

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Homebrewery.Naturalcrit.com



STRUCTURE OF THE WORLD

The basic features of an adventure setting can be categorized into geographic dimensions, measures of time, factions, meta-plot, encounters, and so on. The following pages provide descriptions and guidelines on how to create, structure and run these for a procedural adventure setting that still has that specific Dragonbane feeling to it.

SPACIAL DIMENSIONS

The basic geographic structure of an adventure setting can be divided into regions, areas, adventure sites, and locations – ordered from largest to smallest. Each level is relevant for a different aspect of the game and offers different features and random tables.

MEASURING TIME

In addition to the normal three units of time, this supplement introduces 2 additional units to measure longer durations. A week is about the time required to travel to and from an adventure site and to plan and resolve faction missions.

UNIT OF TIME	DURATION	ENOUGH TIME TO...
Week	5–8 days	Play through an adventure site, resolve a faction mission.
Season	~90 days	Heal severe injuries, resolve a long-term faction mission.

GEOGRAPHY

REGIONS

A region is the largest mechanically relevant place of an adventure. The maps included in official adventures depict regions – with exceptions (see box below).

- ♦ **Meta-Plot:** A region holds an plot or adventure arc that is played out in the various adventure sites.
- ♦ **Factions:** There should be a number of factions active in a region, that can be encountered frequently.
- ♦ **Regional Events:** Some regions have random events tables for events that affect the whole region.

ALTERNATE SCALES

SMALLER THAN A REGION: If it does not make sense to divide an adventure setting into multiple areas – if it takes place in a large city like Arkand or the dwarven mines of the Gates of Power (Path of Glory) – it can simply consist of a single area without defining a full region.

MULTIPLE REGIONS: A larger adventure setting can feature multiple regions. In this case, each region should still have its distinct overarching plot and distinct factions to warrant the separation into regions. It should also be made clear how the regions connect, by what means of transport the party can get from one to the other, and how long it takes them to get there.

AREAS

Map areas are parts of a region, unified by a similar landscape, vegetation and general vibe or feeling.

- ♦ **Journeys:** Areas structure journeys in the region, each area takes about a day to a week to cross.
- ♦ **Random Encounters Table:** Each area has a random encounters table that determines what you can discover during travel.

ADVENTURE SITES

Adventure sites encompass a self-contained part of an adventure, like a village, a dungeon or castle. An adventure site is the place where adventures play out.

- ♦ **Overview Map:** An adventure site provides an overview map with numbered locations for orientation.
- ♦ **Random Events Table:** This table holds wandering monsters, traps or other events and is triggered each stretch the party spends in the adventure site.

LOCATIONS

Locations are the single rooms, halls, courtyards and other spaces that make up the adventure site.

- ♦ **Descriptions:** Each location holds descriptions on which traps, hidden treasure, monsters, or NPCs are present, and exits leading to other locations.
- ♦ **Encounter Die Size:** Locations can have different die sizes to roll on the adventure site's random events table to limit what can happen here.

THE META-PLOT

The meta-plot is the big thing that is currently going on in the region. It is what generates the conflict between the factions. A fight for control of the region – like the search for a powerful artifact, struggle for power, or conflicting ideas on how to deal with a common threat.

FACTION GOALS

The meta-plot determines the goals of a faction in the region. Factions can have larger goals, like re-establishing the empire, that transcend their regional goals. But the goals relevant for play are about what they seek in this region – like searching for the ancient crown.

Factions can have completely asymmetric goals that nonetheless come into conflict with each other. An example would be the druid circle that wants to heal nature and the settlers fleeing from a war trying to tame the land to settle here.

PLOT PROGRESS

A good meta-plot should have a simple way to measure the player character's and faction's progress towards their goals. This can be the number of keys gathered, proportion of strategically important sites conquered, number of villages liberated, or something similar.

EXAMPLE META-PLOTS

HUNT FOR THE KEYS

The most used meta-plot in Dragonbane adventures so far has been factions looking for parts of a key to a powerful artifact. In this meta-plot, the different factions all have the same primary goal: to find the keys and get the artifact first.

A GAME OF THRONES

A more subtle meta-plot is different factions competing for power over the region – ordering assassinations, stealing secrets, and even engaging in small skirmishes. In this scenario, factions either have the goal to gain power or prevent others from gaining it, and tend to use different methods – either subterfuge or overt force.

ALL OUT WAR

The most terrible type of conflict between factions is an all-out war. The goal of factions engaged in war have the goal of destroying each other. A war can also break out between political factions vying for power when court intrigue and proxy-battles are no longer effective.

THE HUB

It is always good to have a regional hub – like Outskirt (in the Core Set Adventures) – a camp, village or town where the player characters can rest safely, buy and sell gear, and hear the latest rumors about adventure sites.

RUMORS

The regional hub is where player characters can hear rumors. That is why a hub has a Rumors Table. Each rumor should point the player characters to an adventure site or to a place in town, where an adventure scenario takes place.

FACTION RUMORS: When factions start missions, people will notice and talk about what they saw or heard. This gossip can then be added to the rumor table. A rumor about a faction mission should not reveal the mission's goal, but should alert the player characters that something is going on in an adventure site.

BACKDROP

Beside the main factions in the adventure, there are many other communities, monsters, bandits, or other beings who dwell in the region and have their own habits and interests.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Each area of a region has its own random encounter table. Such a table contains not only combat encounters with monsters and bandits, but also interesting landmarks or the area, sightings of awe-inspiring beasts, or chance encounters with friendly NPCs.

BACKDROP RUMORS: Some rumors have nothing to do with faction activities, but are about other things going on in the region – like ancient ruins bearing treasure, a local community or tribe who are wary but not necessarily hostile towards the player characters, or a monster that has recently attacked a farm or merchant.

LANDS OF ROULIMAR

The adventure takes place in the Lands of Roulimar, a relatively secluded region on the eastern shore of the continent, to the north of the Eastern Lands.

HISTORY

Roulimar has long been inhabited by nightkin and wolfkin, before Eledain's Dragon Empire expanded here and displaced its former people to the barren fringes of the region. The goblins and nightkin have mostly withdrawn to the mountains and the Blackmoore Bogs. Meanwhile the wolfkin clans have mostly withdrawn to the peninsula of the Icewater Cove.

THE CURRENT SITUATION

A couple of years ago, the blood-seer Romuluk, of the Bloodreaver wolfkin clan, communed with an ancient spirit called "Aistra" during a ritual of reading deer entrails. The ancient demon presented herself as a mighty spirit of the hunt. She commanded Romuluk to gather his reavers and teach them her blood-rage. Ever since, the Aistra's manic reavers have been spreading fear and terror across the region.

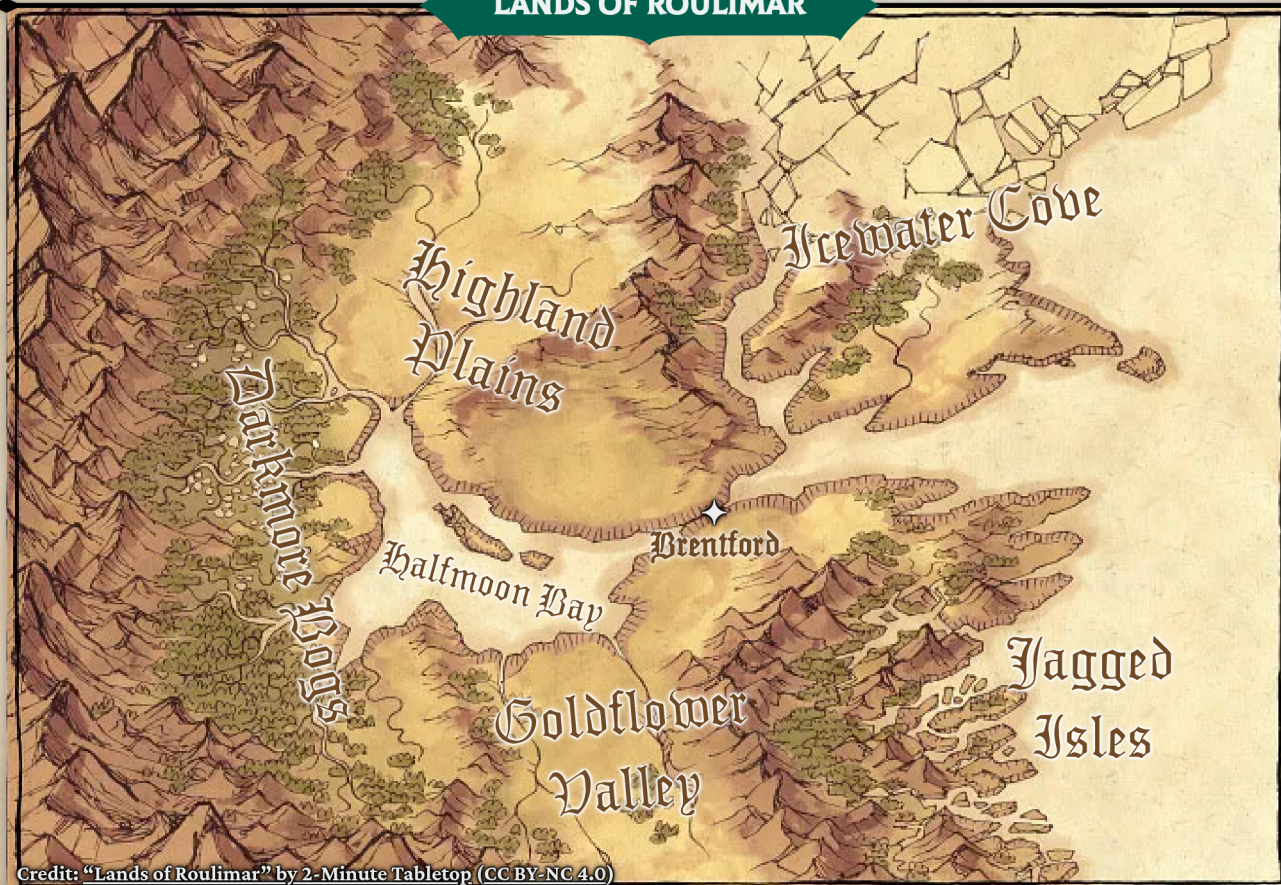
REGIONAL EVENTS

The lands of Roulimar are marked by the growing power of the demon lord Aistra. Whenever the GM finds it fitting, or about once every week, you can roll on the table below for a dark portent that proclaims Aistra's influence.

D6 GRIM PORTENTS

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | DARK STORM. The sky darkens with heavy clouds and icy hail, reddish lightning flashes nearby. |
| 2 | EARTHQUAKE. The ground shakes throughout the region. Cracks and fissures form. |
| 3 | BLOODMOON. During a full night, the moon shines in the color of fresh blood. |
| 4 | VISIONS. Everyone in the region has dreams of a blood-soaked hunt, red in tooth and claw. |
| 5 | CRAZE. A random NPC goes into a crazed rage and attacks everyone nearby. It only lasts a stretch. |
| 6 | LYCANTHROPY. A werewolf has been spotted near or in one of the human or halfling settlements. |

LANDS OF ROULIMAR



Credit: "Lands of Roulimar" by 2-Minute Tabletop (CC BY-NC 4.0)

AREAS

There are about half a dozen larger areas in the Lands of Roulimar that are distinguished by their landscape, ecology or factional presence. Each of them has its own table of random encounters and hold many adventure locations. Here are only a few of them.

GOLDFLOWER VALLEY

A fertile valley dominated by two large rivers, Goldflower Valley is the most populated area in the region. Many humans and halflings have built farms and villages here.

DARKMORE BOGS

Thick bogs and swamps stretch along the western shoreline of Halfmoon Bay. Here, goblins and other outcasts hide in their camps and lairs for unwitting travelers.

HIGHLAND PLAINS

The wind-swept plains to the north of Halfmoon Bay are less welcoming than the valleys to the south.

ICEWATER COVE

The frozen shoreline in the north of Roulimar is the most inhospitable place in the region. Most remaining wolfkin tribes call this peninsula their home.

JAGGED ISLES

The small islands that make up the southern coast are a major hazard to ships and boats in the region.

BRENTFORD

The central hub in the Lands of Roulimar is the town of Brentford, strategically set on the narrow straight separating Halfmoon Bay from the eastern Ocean. While it is not the largest city, Brentford is an important trade port for the region.

Here, an adventure group can hear the current news and rumors about problems and treasures in the region.

EXAMPLE RUMORS

D4 RUMOR

- 1 **HOWLING FORT.** *"On the southern shore of Icewater Cove stands an old abandoned fort of the old empire. You can hear howling from within every night."*
- 2 **MERMAID'S TROVE.** *"Over a decade ago, a pirate ship called the Mermaid's Trove sunk somewhere along the jagged Isles. They say it holds many riches."*
- 3 **TIMMERDALE.** *"A wealthy merchant was brutally murdered down in Timmerdale. Nobody trusts each other there anymore. But some say a monster did it."*
- 4 **IRON HALLS.** *"The dwarven mine in the north-west was abandoned long ago. The dwarfs found many riches but also unleashed a shadow from the deep."*

EXAMPLE RANDOM ENCOUNTERS IN THE DARKMORE BOGS

D12 EVENT

- 1-6 **NOTHING HAPPENS.** The treetops lightly rustle in the wind, you trudge over muddy ground.
- 7 **LEECHES.** A flooded section of the path is riddled with leeches. Anyone wading through the water must roll BUSHCRAFT or take D3 damage and suffer a condition of their choice. Armor has no effect.
- 8 **GOBLIN BANDITS.** A gang of goblins jumps out from the bushes, bows and swords drawn and aimed. "Give us your treasures!" the head goblin yells, "Or we loot it from your dead bodies!" The goblins outnumber the PCs by one and have the stats of typical goblin scout (Rulebook p.90). They flee if half of them are defeated.
- 9 **HUNTING TRAP.** An old bear trap is hidden under a bunch of leaves. All player characters must make an AWARENESS roll in walking order. The first to fail their roll triggers the trap and suffers D6 piercing damage.
- 10 **BOG HORSE.** A greenish-gray horse stands on a small dry patch in the middle of a stagnant pond. It whinnies wildly – seemingly trapped and in distress. The horse is in fact a brook horse (Bestiary p.72) trying to trap the PCs in the bog and feast on them. An AWARENESS roll reveals a previous victim just below the pond's surface.
- 11 **ANCIENT PAVILLION.** The remains of an elven pavillion stands half broken and skewed out of the swamp. It was made of stone and intricately decorated with floral patterns. Now it is overgrown with vines and moss. Player characters who examine the structure with a SPOT HIDDEN roll can find one treasure card.
- 12 **GIANT SPIDER.** A hungry giant spider (Rulebook p.89) has spun its web across the path. All player characters must make an AWARENESS roll – those who fail are trapped in the spider's web (monster attack #5) and the spider attacks next round. The trapped characters must roll STR with a bane to break free.

FACTIONS

“When you play the game of thrones, you win or you die. There is no middle ground.”

— GEORGE R.R. MARTIN, *A GAME OF THRONES*

Factions are groups of NPCs who have interests that can align with or come into conflict with those of the player characters. In a typical Dragonbane adventure, you should have at least three factions major with conflicting goals and methods. Their struggle for control and victory generates a dynamic background to your ongoing adventure setting.

Factions pursue their own goals in the adventure region. They send out their members and special agents to settlements or adventure sites to conquer them, find powerful artefacts or prevent other factions from achieving oppose goals. This interplay of factions can make an adventure setting more dynamic and alive. This chapter offers GM procedures to support this type of play.

FEATURES

Each faction is made up of a number of defining features and components. Each of these has both a narrative role to flesh out the faction in the world and a mechanical purpose to prepare and resolve faction missions in between game sessions.

SIZE: The size of a faction reflects the number of its followers and determines its starting **UNITS** and **ASSETS**.

TYPE: A faction's type is a shorthand for its distinct nature or defining identity. It informs both who its members are and what shared goals brings them together.

GOALS: A faction has one or two goals that inform their activities. Goals can include both what the faction aims to achieve, but also a creed it adheres to.

RELATIONSHIPS: A faction has relations and attitudes towards each other factions and the player characters.

MISSIONS: A faction undertakes missions to enhance their power or progress towards their goals. Typical missions include: recruiting new members, searching assets or attacking a rival faction.

UNITS: The most visible part of a faction are the units they send on missions. There are two types of units: **AGENTS**, like knights or spies, who work alone and **GROUPS** of four to six low-ranking faction members.

ASSETS: Factions own real estate, wealth, tamed monsters or powerful magic items to further their goals. Assets can't do anything on their own but must be used by a faction unit on a mission.

THE RULE OF THREE

To create the three major factions in your adventure setting, you can use the “the good, the bad, and the ugly” rule of thumb. Use the tables on the following pages to randomly generate the three major factions, or use them as inspiration or come up with your own ideas.

THE GOOD: A self-righteous faction, like a knights' order or political institution that seeks to spread law and order. They tend to follow clear rules and codes, but can bend them for the greater good. However, their idea of “goodness” can be questionable.

THE BAD: A chaotic faction that uses stealth and subterfuge or pure force and violence to achieve its selfish and power-hungry ambitions. They can become allied to the PCs but will likely betray them. Individual members might be redeemable, but not the whole faction itself.

THE UGLY: The third faction is the most open for interpretation. It should be something weird and out of the ordinary like a wild or untamable horde, a nightkin clan, rebellious farmers or band of pirates. To ally with them, the PCs must first prove themselves.

OTHER FACTIONS

DIFFERENT TYPES: The good, the bad and the ugly rule is simply meant as a rough guide to get started. If you want to deviate from this formula, you can adapt the tables as you see fit.

MORE FACTIONS: You can add more than the main three factions to the region. Just add another good, bad or ugly faction, but best pick one that is clearly distinct from the existing ones.

Be aware that if you add too many factions, they run the danger of losing their character and distinctiveness.

SMALLER FACTIONS: It can be useful to add a few factions that are smaller the big three, or limited to a specific area or settlement – like a lizardkin hunting expedition in the eastern swamps. This way, they take less spotlight from the big three but still add to the flavor of the setting.

CREATING FACTIONS

On the following pages are detailed tables to create three major factions for an adventure region. These tables are first and foremost meant as an inspiration to get you started on fleshing out the factions. Use them as a starting point. Add and tweak any aspect to better make the factions fit your world.

To randomly generate a faction, you can roll a D4, D6, D8, D10, D12, D20 and look up the results on the tables. The dice stand for faction size (D4, to the right), type (D6, below), relationships (D8, page 8), history or secret (D10 and D12, page 9) and starting assets (D20, page 9).

FACTION SIZE

The faction's size reflects how many starting resources it has. Distribute D4 + 5 points among **GROUPS**, **AGENTS** and **ASSETS** or roll a D4 on the table below to set it.

D4	SIZE	GROUPS	AGENTS	ASSETS
1	Scrappy	2	3	1
2	Exclusive	1	3	3
3	Forceful	5	2	1
4	Powerful	4	3	2

FACTION TYPES

D6	THE GOOD	THE BAD	THE UGLY
1	KNIGHT'S ORDER 1: Destroy demonic evil 2: Protect the realm 3: Establish religious order	DEMON CULTISTS 1: Liberate a demon lord 2: Corrupt the innocent 3: Gain personal power	NIGHTKIN HORDE 1: Reclaim their own land 2: Dominate the daykin 3: Restore the natural order
2	MAGICIAN'S CIRCLE 1: Gain ancient magical powers 2: Expand political influence 3: Control all magic in the realm	POWERFUL NECROMANCER 1: Conjure an army of undead 2: Reanimate a dead loved one 3: Achieve eternal life	WITCHES' COVEN 1: Revenge past mistreatment 2: Re-establish the old ways 3: Protect their own
3	ELVEN COUNCIL 1: Protect nature's balance 2: Safeguard the elven realms 3: Unite their disparate people	VAMPIRE COURT 1: End the tyranny of the sun 2: Keep the livestock unaware 3: End a rival dynasty	ORGANIZED BANDITS 1: Take from the rich 2: Give to the poor 3: Gain their own feudal power
4	THE ROYAL COURT 1: Enforce law and order 2: Conquer neighboring lands 3: Defend the realm	CORRUPT NOBLES 1: Gain political power 2: Maximize personal profit 3: Exploit the peasantry	REBELLIOUS PEASANTS 1: Overthrow the local nobility 2: Establish a republic 3: Gain basic rights and freedoms
5	ADVENTURING GUILD 1: Make profit from treasure 2: Discover exciting new lands 3: Gain fame and glory	INVADING ARMY 1: Conquer the realm 2: Raid and pillage villages 3: Eradicate the population	NATURE'S GUARDIANS 1: Protect untouched nature 2: Destroy sites of civilization 3: Nurture natural beauty
6	COLLEGE OF KNOWLEDGE 1: Uncover ancient knowledge 2: Record unfolding history 3: Monopolize learning	CRIMINAL SYNDICATE 1: Wealth through theft and cons 2: Assassination for hire 3: Dominate their territory	BEASTKIN CLANS 1: Carve out their own place 2: Live free from oppression 3: Make a profit from trade

FACTION GOALS

For each faction, choose at least one overarching goal or ideology. These goals guide their conduct and interests of a faction. They also inform a faction's specific goals in a region and how they interact with other factions, with commoners and with the player characters.

The faction type table offers three general goals for each type of faction. A faction does not need to have all of them, but can have anywhere from 1 to 3 goals. You can roll a D3 for them, pick whichever fits well or simply take them as inspiration and write your own. Use other faction features to adapt these goals to the region.

FACTION RELATIONSHIPS

The three major factions have certain attitudes towards each other. At best they see the others as competition or are unaware of the other, at worst they are openly hostile. Each faction should have at least one attitude towards each of the other faction. These attitudes determine how faction units react to members of other faction when they meet them in the world.

To set the starting attitudes of a faction, roll a D8 on the table below for their relationship with each of the other two factions.

Alternatively, you can roll one D8 for the Good's attitude towards the Bad, One for the Bad's attitude towards the Ugly, and one for the Ugly's towards the Good – and fill in the reciprocal attitudes as makes sense.

FACTION ATTITUDES

D8	TOWARDS THE "GOOD"	TOWARDS THE "BAD"	TOWARDS THE "UGLY"
1	Has been oppressed by them for centuries (hostile)	Has lost many people to their schemes and plots (hostile)	Has been repeatedly attacked or raided by them (hostile)
2	Was betrayed by them during a past alliance (hostile)	Finds their beliefs dangerous, heretical or evil (hostile)	Are in open conflict over land or property (hostile)
3	Is obstructed by their rigid rule and law enforcement (distrusting)	Stands in direct competition over influence or power (distrusting)	Blames them for the current woes: a drought or plague (distrusting)
4	They refused aid in a moment of dire need (distrusting)	Was the target of their plots and schemes in the past (distrusting)	Sees them as worthless or inferior (distrusting)
5	Has a past of rivalry and respect with them (ambivalent)	Was given aid in the past but at a considerable cost (ambivalent)	They share our beliefs, but their ways are different (ambivalent)
6	Sees them as naïve do-gooders, easily dealt with (indifferent)	Is largely unaware of them at the moment (indifferent)	Primarily sees them as strange but harmless (indifferent)
7	Have been helped by them in a moment of need (friendly)	Are deceived about their true nature and goals (friendly)	Has bought their support with treasure, aid or land (friendly)
8	Is bound to loyalty to them by a sacred or magical oath (allied)	Is secretly controlled by them (allied), roll D8 for official stance	Have made a secret pact to pursue a shared goal (allied)

PLAYER CHARACTER STANDING

Just as factions have certain relationships to each other, they have a certain relationship to the player characters. At the start of an adventure, the *good* faction has an **INDIFFERENT** attitude towards the player characters, while the *bad* and the *ugly* are both **DISTRUSTING**

REPUTATION: You can use the reputation rules to track the player characters' reputation with members of a factions. Directly aiding or interfering with a faction mission counts as an extraordinary deed.

REPUTATION SCORE: The reputation score is the sum of good deeds plus bad deeds on the faction reputation list. With a score above 5, the faction becomes ambivalent instead of indifferent between -1 and 1.

STANDING: The standing with a faction is equal to your good deeds minus bad deeds on the faction reputation list. It represents the faction's regard for and determines their attitude towards the player character.

STANDING	ATTITUDE
≤ -4	Hostile
-2 – -3	Distrusting
-1 – 1	Indifferent or Ambivalent
2 – 5	Friendly
≥ 6	Allied

ADDITIONAL DETAILS

To add some more flavor and background to a faction, roll a D10 and D12 on the table below to determine what kind of leadership it has and what secret or past indiscretions the faction is trying to hide.

DETAILS

ROLL	D10: LEADERSHIP	D12: SECRET
1	Fierce warrior	Family ties to the enemy
2	Wise elder	Is infiltrated by a mole
3	Keen strategist	Caused a recent plague
4	Visionary thinker	Hides the one true heir
5	Squabbling council	Stole local food supplies
6	Charismatic talker	Leader worships false gods
7	Nurturing caretaker	Internal power struggles
8	Ambitious egoist	Owes a lot of money
9	Zealous maniac	Abducts and interrogates
10	Petty coward	Vengeful former members
11		Is built on a lie
12		Sacrifices innocent people

STARTING ASSETS & UNITS

Each faction starts with a number of resources according to its size (page 7). The starting resources are divided into **GROUPS**, **AGENTS** and **ASSETS**. You can redistribute them to better suit the faction, with the limitation that at least half of a faction's resources need to be **UNITS**.

For example, an exclusive (2) faction starts with 7 resources. While its starting distribution is 1 **GROUP**, 3 **AGENTS** and 3 **ASSETS**, you can get an additional **AGENT** and lose one **ASSET**, but not the other way around.

GROUPS: Any type of low-level NPC can be grouped together to form a **GROUP**. You can use the stats for bandits, guards or cultists from the typical NPCs table in the Rulebook (p.105) for the individual members of a group.

AGENTS: **AGENTS** are NPCs that can work alone and have at least one heroic ability. Most named NPCs in published adventures can work as examples for **AGENTS**.

ASSETS: Anything from a magic item to great wealth can count as a faction **ASSET**. Roll on the table to the right to randomly pick starting **ASSETS** for a faction. Or pick, adapt or create **ASSETS** that best fit the faction.

EXAMPLE ASSETS

D20 ASSET

- GREAT WEALTH:** Money makes everything easier. Any mission inside a settlement gets a boon.
- MAGIC ARTIFACT:** A magic item of the GMs choice. (See the Book of Magic for inspiration)
- TAMED MONSTER:** Any monster with ferocity up to 2 that follows a trainer's (**AGENT**) commands.
- SPY NETWORK:** Spies throughout most settlements provide information on other factions.
- STRONGHOLD:** A fortified headquarters making it impossible to simply attack units within it.
- PORTAL:** It goes somewhere. The demon realm? A far away land? Its specific uses are unclear.
- TROVE OF KNOWLEDGE:** The faction holds a library or vault giving a boon to knowledge rolls.
- POLITICAL INFLUENCE:** The faction can petition a higher power to force others to negotiate.
- FORMIDABLE MOUNTS:** A stable of riding worgs or war horses, enough for a **GROUP**.
- WATER VEHICLE:** The faction owns a ship or boat that carries up to 20 people and cross water.
- FOUNTAIN OF LIFE:** Units that make it back, no matter how wounded, fully heal within a week.
- ORACLE:** A seer or magic mirror can predict the next missions difficulties, giving a boon to it.
- OCCULT RITUAL:** The instructions to summon a demon or awaken an ancient dragon (one use).
- TELEPORT CIRCLE:** Members have stones that allow them to immediately teleport back home.
- MAGIC WEAPONS:** Magic weapons with a rank 1 enchantment (Book of Magic) for their **AGENTS**.
- FOREIGN SUPPORT:** The faction can call for back-up and gain 3 **GROUPS** or **AGENTS** in a month.
- SKELETON KEY:** An **AGENT** using the key can open any non-magical lock without rolling.
- MESSENGERS:** Messenger bats or birds that carry information about missions back within a day.
- LABORATORY:** A skilled alchemist **AGENT** can create potions and poisons for the faction.
- FLYING VEHICLE:** A balloon or air ship that can carry up to 10 people. It is half as fast as on foot but can ignore any difficult terrain.

FACTION MISSIONS

A faction undertakes missions to enhance their power or progress towards their goals. Typical missions include recruiting new followers, searching new assets in adventure sites, increasing their power in a settlement, or attacking a rival faction.

SETTING UP MISSIONS

Factions undertake missions to further their goals. Set up new missions and resolve ongoing missions between sessions so that the world changes once the PCs return to a settlement from an adventure site.

To set up a mission, the faction must have a free UNIT to assign to it. Missions aim to further a faction's goals, like acquiring assets, attacking an enemy, recruiting more units, or opposing a rival faction's mission.

RUMORS TABLE: Unless a faction deploys a secret agent, a faction mission adds an entry to the rumors table or card deck available to the players – something like “The brotherhood is searching for an ancient temple in the Thornwood” or “The thieves guild is recruiting again”.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS: If a faction sends their units to an adventure site, they can be encountered during travel in the area, if they keep guard posts or patrols in the surrounding area, or when they are still searching for a well-hidden adventure site. Decide whether they are generally hostile, neutral or friendly towards the PCs.

ADVENTURE STIES: If a faction mission sends a unit to an adventure site, it takes a certain amount of time to com-

plete, see below. During this time the units will be present at the adventure site and can be helped or hindered by the player characters or by another faction.

MISSION DURATION

Every mission takes a certain time to carry out. Normal, simple missions only take up to a week but will also only return common rewards. More complex missions can take several weeks to conclude but promise much more valuable rewards.

RESOLVING MISSIONS

Before setting up new missions between sessions, check whether any ongoing missions are about to end. If player characters were involved in an ongoing mission, whether it succeeds or fails is resolved during play. The faction gains or loses UNIT or ASSET accordingly.

If the player characters are not involved in a mission, at the end of the mission's duration roll on the highest relevant skill rating among all involved UNITS.

- ♦ If the roll succeeds, the mission succeeds and the faction gains its benefits.
- ♦ If the roll fails, the mission fails.
- ♦ If a rival faction opposes a mission, resolve both sides with an open opposed roll, only the winning side succeeds in their mission.
- ♦ On a dragon, the winners gain an extra reward, but on a demon, one of their UNITS or ASSETS is lost.

MISSION TYPES

A faction mission can take many forms and have many goals, but the most common ones are summarized below. How to resolve a mission is described above.

RECRUIT: A faction can send a UNIT to recruit more followers in a suitable settlement. The UNIT must roll for **PERSUASION**. The roll gains banes depending on the general population's attitude towards the faction. If it succeeds, the faction gains a new **GROUP** or **AGENT**.

ATTACK: The unit makes an open opposed roll on their best weapon skill versus the target's **EVADE** or their best weapon skill (15 for monsters). Each side rolls onces per UNIT and counts their successes and failures.

For each success on a weapon skill, the faction kills one of the other faction's UNITS. Each success on **EVADE** cancels out an opposing success on a weapon skill.

PROTECT: A unit can be tasked to protect itself or a faction asset. It cannot do anything else during the week but gain a boon on rolls to defend against an attack or interference from another faction's UNIT.

ACQUIRE: A faction can send out a UNIT to try to find, steal or purchase an **ASSET**. To uncover an ancient artefact requires a **SPOT HIDDEN** or **MYTHS & LEGENDS** roll, to steal it a **STEALTH** or **SLEIGHT OF HAND**, and to acquire it from a merchant a **BARTERING** roll. On a success, the faction gains an **ASSET**.

INTERFERE: Units can interfere with another faction's mission in many ways. If they do so, they can make another UNIT's roll to resolve its mission an open opposed roll. The interfering UNIT uses a skill suitable for the type of interference they attempt.

EXAMPLE FACTIONS



KNIGHTS ORDER OF THE CLEANSING FIRE

Exclusive "Good" Faction

Another offshoot of the Keepers of the Immaculate Flame, these knights see themselves as the only true heirs to Eledain's ancient dragon knights. The order stands for the cleansing of the corrupted with fire and sword, and adhere to strict codes of purity, truth, duty, and order. They carry a banner of stylized dragon wings gleaming with light.

GOALS: Re-establish the Dragon Empire, oppose the machinations of any demon and banish them, and hunt her followers and cultists with a fierce determination.

ATTITUDES:

- ♦ Indifferent towards the adventurers
- ♦ The Reavers are dangerous and heretical (hostile)
- ♦ The Grinning Skull is worthless scum (distrusting)

UNITS: The three dragon knights Thorfinn, Mereniel and Herderik (**AGENTS**); dragon squires (**GROUP**).

ASSETS: Each knight carries an ancient longsword, war-hammer, or mace that glows near demons; Messenger ravens; Can call other Dragon Knights for support once.

MISSIONS:

- ♦ Recruit squires or hire mercenaries (+**GROUP**)
- ♦ Uncover ancient dragon empire artefacts (+**ASSET**)
- ♦ Bring an enemy **GROUP** or **AGENT** to swift justice



REAVERS OF AISTRA

Forceful "Bad" Faction

Aistra is the incarnation of feral rage, blood-lust and the visceral hunt of natural predators. While she hails from a demonic realm of madness and chaos, some of the wolfkin clans of the north view her as an ancient natural force. Her worshippers paint themselves in the blood of their prey and cut a cross of claw marks into their own flesh.

GOALS: Aistra revels in the ecstasy of the primal hunt. Her followers seek to retake their home region and convert all wolfkin to her wild and feral ways.

ATTITUDES:

- ♦ Distrusting of the adventurers
- ♦ They lost many people to the Knights (hostile)
- ♦ Grinning Skulls are odd but harmless (indifferent)

UNITS: 5x Wolfkin reavers (**GROUP**); The blood-seer Romuluk (**AGENT**); Bloodmoon assassin Husk (**AGENT**)

ASSETS: A **SUMMON CHAMPION** (Book of Magic p.32) ritual scroll for a blood demon (Bestiary p.136)

MISSIONS:

- ♦ Raid a nearby human farm or village (+**ASSET**)
- ♦ Convert from other wolfkin clans (+**GROUP**)
- ♦ Hunt down and kill a rival **GROUP** or **AGENT**



GRINNING SKULL BANDITS

Scrappy "Ugly" Faction

A cunning goblin chief Gut has united the goblins and hobgoblins of the region, and even a few orcs and ogres under her banner. Her gang seeks to gain treasure, and follows the creed that you own what you can keep away from others. They have gathered in hideouts in the Darkmore Bogs, raiding and robbing nearby villages and traveling merchants.

GOALS: While the goblins ultimately seek to take back their land from the "daykin" (humans and halflings), they are happy to steal their property, for now.

ATTITUDES:

- ♦ Distrusting of the adventurers.
- ♦ Obstructed by the Knights (distrusting)
- ♦ Had been targeted by the Reavers (distrusting)

UNITS: Goblin scouts (**GROUP**); Hobgoblin warriors (**GROUP**); The goblin bandit chief Gut (**AGENT**); The ogre twins Mog and Mrak (**AGENTS**)

ASSETS: A bandit camp hidden in the Darkmore Bogs

MISSIONS:

- ♦ Raise a champion among the ranks (+**AGENT**)
- ♦ Raid a nearby daykin farm or convoy (+**ASSET**)
- ♦ Covertly assassinate a rival faction **AGENT**

NEGOTIATIONS

When the player characters engage in formal talks with a representative of a faction – like an audience with a faction leader, or parlay with an opposed faction – use the following procedure to structure a negotiation scene.

Negotiations basically work like death rolls (Rulebook p.50). You must make a certain number of successful rolls before you make a number of failed rolls.

STARTING TALKS

To start formal talks, one player character must introduce the group and state their intentions clearly. You can roll on **PERSUASION** to communicate your open and honest desire to talk, **BLUFFING** to trick the other side into talking, or **PERFORMANCE** to make formal introductions in accordance with local custom or dazzle the audience.

- ♦ If the roll fails, they start with their normal patience (see the table on the right).
- ♦ If the roll succeeds, you gain +1 patience for the talks, or +2 if you roll a dragon.

You can not attempt to take up a finished negotiation a second time before any major changes have happened.

BREAKING OFF TALKS

If during a negotiation, the player characters or a third party interferes by performing hostile or disruptive actions, the negotiation ends and all has to be taken up from the beginning, if desired.

When attempting to start a broken off negotiation a second time before any major changes have happened, the other party's patience starts with -1. This means that you cannot simply try to take up a negotiation with hostile faction a second time.

RELUCTANCE

The other party's **RELUCTANCE** to grant your request determines how many successes you need to convince them. You can use the following list of questions to determine their **RELUCTANCE**. Increase or decrease their **RELUCTANCE** according to the questions.

- ♦ Does it require the other party to sacrifice or give up something important to them? (+1)
- ♦ Does it expose the other party to great risk? (+1)
- ♦ Is it contrary the other party's goals or beliefs? (+1)
- ♦ Do you already owe the other party a debt? (+1)
- ♦ Are they **DISTRUSTING** towards you? (+1)
- ♦ Are they **HOSTILE** towards you? (+2)
- ♦ Does other party owe you a debt? (-1)
- ♦ Are you **ALLIED** with the other party? (-1)

PATIENCE

The other party comes into a negotiation with a certain degree of **PATIENCE**, set by their general attitude towards you and how well you initiated the talks. The player characters can increase the other party's **PATIENCE** with a good roll for introductions.

ATTITUDES & PATIENCE

ATTITUDE	BEHAVIOUR	PATIENCE
Hostile	Will attack and hunt you	0
Distrusting	Mistrusted but not hostile	1
Indifferent	No benefits, no problems	2
Friendly	Trusted but not blindly	3
Allied	Will assist you in a fight	4

EXAMPLE NEGOTIATION

The player characters are meeting with Gut, the leader of the Grinning Skull Bandits. They want to propose a temporary truce and alliance to fight against the Reavers of Aistra. Since Gut distrusts them, they only get a patience of 1, but since they make a successful introduction and gain +1, for a total **PATIENCE** of 2.

Since the bandits are distrusting towards the player characters, they already start with a **RELUCTANCE** of 1. Such a truce would mean that the bandits can no

longer plunder, that would be a sacrifice (+1); It would expose goblins to risk in battle (+1); However it does not go directly against their goals, and there are no open debts on either side. In total, the party needs to overcome the goblin's **RELUCTANCE** of 3.

SUCCESSES:	○—○—○	RELUCTANCE 3
FAILURES:	○—○	PATIENCE 2

MAKING ARGUMENTS

During negotiation, every player character can try to make an argument and roll on one of the skills below. Each argument roll has one of the following effects:

- ♦ **Success:** Either gain 1 **SUCCESS** or learn about the other party's **DISLIKE**, **TRAIT** or **MOTIVATION**.
- ♦ **Dragon:** You can pick twice from the success list.
- ♦ **Failure:** Mark off 1 **PATIENCE**
- ♦ **Demon:** Mark off 2 **PATIENCE**

Each argument during a negotiation must either use a different skill or be made by a different player character.

PERSUASION: If you make a reasonable argument or point out a bad outcome if they deny your request.

BARTERING: If you offer gold, treasure or other valuables in exchange for them agreeing with your request.

BLUFFING: If you use a lie about a threat or danger, make false promises, or lie about who you really are.

If you fail **BLUFFING** and are caught in a lie, the other party becomes **DISGRUNTLED** and the player characters get a bane for the rest of the negotiation.

INSIGHT: A player character with the **INSIGHT** heroic ability can use **AWARENESS** to find out a **DISLIKE**, **TRAIT** or **MOTIVATION** without the risk of marking off patience. This can only be used once during a negotiation.

PERFORMANCE: If you try to get on their good side with a song, poem, flattery or performance.

OTHER: You can try other skills or use magic spells to influence the negotiation. The GM has final say whether you can try or whether it breaks off the negotiation.

NPC MOTIVATION

Dragonbane NPCs typically have traits and motivation (Rulebook p.106) that can be used for negotiations. In addition, representatives of a faction also adhere to their faction's goals. In this supplement, you can also roll a D8, D10 and D12 on the table below to give them each a **DISLIKE**, **TRAIT** and **MOTIVATION**.

- ♦ For each **MOTIVATION** or **GOAL** used in an argument, or exploited **TRAIT**, or use of a useful piece of information, you gain a boon to a roll. Each piece of information can only be used once during a negotiation.
- ♦ For each **DISLIKE** the argument uses or **TRAIT** it goes against, whether known or not, the roll gets a bane.
- ♦ If an argument goes against a **MOTIVATION** or faction **GOAL**, it becomes an opposed roll against their **WIL**.

NEGOTIATION OUTCOMES

If you feel that you have rolled enough successes, or if the other party's patience reaches zero, tally up the number of successes you have scored and determine the outcome as described below.

- ♦ **Surpassed:** If you score more successes than required, the other party agrees to your proposal and grants you an additional boon or request.
- ♦ **Matched:** If you score exactly as many successes as needed, the other party agrees to your proposal.
- ♦ **Partial Success:** If you score some successes, but less than required, the other party does not agree to your proposal, but will offer you a worse deal or an enemy faction will allow you to retreat unharmed.
- ♦ **No Successes:** If you fail to score any successes, the other faction does not agree with your proposal and offers you nothing – you might want to leave, now!

DISLIKES, TRAITS & MOTIVATIONS

ROLL	D8: DISLIKE	D10: MOTIVATION	D12: TRAIT
1	Being seen as a coward	Amassing wealth and property	Likes hearing themselves talk
2	Unnecessary violence	Attaining knowledge	Is secretly very insecure
3	Naïve belief in justice	Love and passion	Loves to collect curiosities
4	Lack of due deference or gratitude	Upholding oaths and promises	Is highly superstitious
5	People being too greedy	Revenge and retribution	Has a sweet-tooth
6	Overly complicated language	Enjoying beauty and pleasure	Is easily affected by flattery
7	Boring or unimaginative people	Being loyal to blood ties	Fears spells and magic
8	Displays of weakness	Personal pride and honor	Deeply mourns a recent loss
9		Achieve fame and glory	Is afraid of insects
10		Gaining power and influence	Cannot resist a challenge
11			Tends to take advice from allies
12			Is very greedy

FACTION SHEET

**FACTION
NAME:**

FEATURES

TYPE:

GOALS:

LEADERSHIP:

SECRET:

FACTION RELATIONSHIPS

FACTION

ATTITUDE

UNITS & ASSETS

TYPE

DESCRIPTION

PC REPUTATION

D20 ▼ GOOD DEEDS

STANDING:

1

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

9

10

11

12

13

14

15

16

17

18

19

20

D20

▲ BAD DEEDS

FACTIONS & RUMORS

MAP AREA SHEET

**AREA
NAME:**

DESCRIPTION

LANDSCAPE:

CLIMATE:

FAUNA:

VIBES & FEEL:

ADVENTURE SITES

NAME & NOTES

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Roll on a Random Encounters table about every shift.

Or simply select a suitable encounter instead of rolling.

D12 EVENT

1-6 **NOTHING HAPPENS.**

7

8

9

10

11

12

FACTIONS & RUMORS

NPC SHEET

NAME:

FACTION: _____

MOTIVATION: _____

DISLIKE: _____

TRAIT: _____

MOVEMENT: _____

DMG. BONUS: _____

ARMOR: _____

SKILLS: _____

SPECIAL: _____

WEAPONS: _____

HP:

WP:

NAME:

FACTION: _____

MOTIVATION: _____

DISLIKE: _____

TRAIT: _____

MOVEMENT: _____

DMG. BONUS: _____

ARMOR: _____

SKILLS: _____

SPECIAL: _____

WEAPONS: _____

HP:

WP:

NAME:

FACTION: _____

MOTIVATION: _____

DISLIKE: _____

TRAIT: _____

MOVEMENT: _____

DMG. BONUS: _____

ARMOR: _____

SKILLS: _____

SPECIAL: _____

WEAPONS: _____

HP:

WP:

NAME:

FACTION: _____

MOTIVATION: _____

DISLIKE: _____

TRAIT: _____

MOVEMENT: _____

DMG. BONUS: _____

ARMOR: _____

SKILLS: _____

SPECIAL: _____

WEAPONS: _____

HP:

WP: